

THE SPECIALTY

ranked.

I've stayed at 20+ properties across the Caribbean and Mexico. Some are genuinely great. Most are mid. A few should be condemned. Here's what I know — and how I'd think about picking the right one.

See the list →

20+
PROPERTIES STAYED

15+
CARIBBEAN DESTINATIONS

6
BRAND FAMILIES

100%
HONEST TAKES

TOP OF THE LIST

The four I'd book without thinking about it.

Properties I've personally stayed at and would happily send my closest friends to. Featured below. Full list of 17 further down.

THE FULL LIST

17 properties I've actually been to. The takes are real.

This isn't every all-inclusive I'd recommend — it's every one I've personally slept at. DM for the unfiltered version.

01	Excellence Playa Mujeres CANCUN • ADULTS ONLY	The benchmark. Excellence Club non-negotiable.	SPECIALTY
02	Excellence Punta Cana D.R. • ADULTS ONLY	Bigger, livelier, less polished than Playa Mujeres. Get Club or skip.	RECOMMEND
03	Le Blanc Spa Cancun CANCUN • ADULTS ONLY	Sleek, modern, occasionally uptight. For honeymooners.	RECOMMEND
04	Zoetry Agua Punta Cana D.R. • BOUTIQUE	Small, calm, wellness-led. Without the AI energy.	RECOMMEND
05	Atelier Playa Mujeres CANCUN • ADULTS ONLY	Newer, art-forward concept. Service ironing out.	CONDITIONAL
06	Hyatt Ziva Cap Cana D.R. • FAMILY	Best family-friendly DR property. Actual kids' programming.	RECOMMEND
07	Secrets Cap Cana D.R. • ADULTS ONLY	Solid mid-tier. Preferred Club worth the bump. Just fine.	CONDITIONAL
08	Dreams Riviera Cancun CANCUN • FAMILY	Reliable accessible-luxury family. Beach has sargassum issues.	CONDITIONAL
09	Royalton CHIC Punta Cana D.R. • ADULTS ONLY	Loud. Music until late. Party energy. Fine if you're 22.	SPECIFIC AUDIENCE
10	Sandals Royal Caribbean JAMAICA • ADULTS ONLY	If brand-loyal, one of their better properties. Otherwise skip.	CONDITIONAL
11	Sandals Curaçao CURAÇAO • ADULTS ONLY	Newer Sandals. Cleaner aesthetic. Curaçao is the better Sandals destination right now.	RECOMMEND
12	Beaches Turks & Caicos TSC • FAMILY	Best beach of any all-inclusive I've been to. Premium pricing.	RECOMMEND
13	Grand Velas Riviera Maya RIVIERA MAYA • FAMILY/ADULTS	Highest-end AI I've stayed at. Pick Grand Class or skip.	RECOMMEND
14	Rosewood Mayakoba RIVIERA MAYA • BOUTIQUE	Not strictly AI but functions like one. Worth the splurge.	RECOMMEND
15	Andaz Mayakoba RIVIERA MAYA • FAMILY FRIENDLY	Family-friendly, design-forward. The locals' favorite.	RECOMMEND
16	Nizuc Resort & Spa CANCUN • ADULTS/FAMILY	Architectural standout. AI plan optional. Honeymoon-worthy.	RECOMMEND
17	Unico 20'87 RIVIERA MAYA • ADULTS ONLY	Heavy concept (cultural programming, no kids, no logo). Beach is just okay.	RECOMMEND

HOW I'D THINK ABOUT IT

The questions I ask before recommending a property.

Anyone can read the brochure. The right call depends on what you actually want, not on what marketing photos promise.

01

Adults-only or kids? The biggest fork.

Adults-only runs quieter, slower, and usually serves better food. Family resorts have kids' clubs and waterslides but adult dinners get loud. There's no in-between; pick a side.

02

Noise tolerance? Yes, really.

Royalton CHIC has DJs at the pool. Zoetry has acoustic guitar at the pool. Some people love one, some need the other. Marketing photos lie about this — I won't.

03

Mexico, Caribbean, or D.R.? Trade-offs.

Mexico = fastest flight, sharpest design, best food, occasional sargassum. Caribbean = best beaches but limited inventory at top tier. D.R. = biggest variety and best value but more uneven service.

04

Club access or base room? The classic mistake.

Most all-inclusives have a "Club" tier. The price difference is \$200-500/wk per couple. The amenity difference is enormous — private pools, premium liquor, butler, better food. Get Club.

COMMON MISTAKES

Four things people get wrong booking AIs. I see all of them every week.

01

Booking on Booking.com to save money.

You don't save money. The hotel charges the same rate. You just lose the upgrades, club access, breakfast, credits, and human concierge that come with booking through an advisor.

Average value left on the table: ~\$1,200 per couple per week.

02

Picking Sandals because it's famous.

Sandals does heavy marketing. They're fine. They're often not the best option at their price point. Excellence, Le Blanc, and Royalton's adult-only properties typically deliver more for the same money.

Tell your advisor your priorities first; let them recommend the brand, not the other way around.

03

Booking June through October in Riviera Maya.

Sargassum season. Beaches are covered in brown seaweed for half the year. Hotels can clean it but you'll smell it from the lobby. If you must travel summer, go Caribbean (Turks, Anguilla, BVI) or Pacific Mexico.

Nobody books for the resort. They book for the beach. The beach is the product.

04

Not booking Club / Preferred / Premium tier.

The base room is bait pricing. The actual product is the Club tier. You'll spend \$5K either way; the question is whether you arrive to a basic room or to private-pool, premium liquor, butler service.

If your budget is ~\$5K, book Club at a mid-tier resort. Better than base room at a top-tier resort.

READY TO BOOK?

Let me weigh in before you book.

20-minute call. Free. I'll tell you whether your shortlist is right, suggest 2-3 alternatives, and explain the room-tier trade-offs.

No commitment.

Book a 20-min call →

Preface.

Travel for people who'd rather not Expedia it.

TICD #XXXXXXX
FIRA • VIRTUOSO • HYATT PRIVE
28+ ALL-INCLUSIVES STAYED

SERVICES

All-Inclusives
Business Travel
Honeymoons
Family
Bach & Milestone

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